

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



‘FREE THE KIDS’

Why more Chicago families are turning to homeschooling



Above: Aziza Butler, a homeschooling advocate and former Chicago Public Schools teacher on Feb. 5 at WeSchool Academy, a religious microschool she runs in a church building in South Holland. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

At top: Claire Jakubiszyn, director and founder of Blazing Star School, works with students on pen and ink impressions on Feb. 5. Blazing Star is a microschool in Chicago, enrolling almost two dozen children, ages 5 to 14. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

By Kate Armanini | Chicago Tribune

Inside an Irving Park bungalow, kids raced barefoot through the dining room, zooming past paper chains taped to the ceiling. Some slouched in couch chairs, trading stories in a game of Dungeons & Dragons. Others lay on the hardwood floor, flipping through picture books.

Teacher Claire Jakubiszyn knelt beside a 7-year-old boy, counting beads for an art project.

“This is how, even though we don’t do math class, we’re incorporating it through hands-on practice,” she said.

Jakubiszyn’s microschool — or “unschool,” as she calls it — enrolls nearly two dozen students, ages 4 to 14. There are no desks, no tests, no set curriculum, just a small group of teachers to facilitate child-led learning. Most of the kids are homeschoolers who attend part time.

“Children aren’t standard, right? Education shouldn’t be standard. Different kids are going to need different things,” said Jakubiszyn, a former high school arts teacher at a Chicago charter school.

The model may seem unconventional, but it’s gaining ground.

The pandemic supercharged interest in alternative education, from microschools, to homeschooling co-ops, to online learning. Years later, many of those kids haven’t returned to traditional classrooms.

Against the backdrop of national debates over school choice and vouchers, homeschooling has burst from the ideological fringe to the center of Chicago’s education landscape.

Illinois is among a handful of states with virtually no

Turn to Homeschool, Page 4

Martínez shooting evidence released

Bovino praised agent’s conduct after the incident in an email

By Jason Meisner, Caroline Kubzansky and Gregory Royal Pratt
Chicago Tribune

A trove of evidence was released Tuesday in the controversial shooting of Marimar Martínez by an immigration agent at the height of Operation Midway Blitz, including body-worn camera footage showing the tense moments just before their vehicles collided and an email sent later that day by Border Patrol Cmdr. Gregory Bovino praising the agent’s conduct.

“It’s time to get aggressive and get the (expletive) out,” one agent says on a bodycam video as horns blare on Kedzie Avenue in Brighton Park, where Martínez had been following the agents through the neighborhood on the morning of Oct. 4, according to the material released by the U.S. attorney’s office.

Seconds later, the driver, Border Patrol Agent Charles Exum, appears to jerk the steering wheel to the left, in the direction of Martínez’s vehicle alongside

Turn to Evidence, Page 2

Mayor won’t refer ICE agents for prosecution

Johnson faced criticism from Cook County state’s attorney’s office

By Alice Yin and Madeline Buckley
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson on Tuesday said he will not refer alleged cases of misconduct by federal immigration agents to the Cook County state’s attorney’s office, following criticism by the top prosecutor that his “ICE on notice” executive order would politicize investigations.

Cook County State’s Attorney Eileen O’Neill Burke released a memo last week saying Johnson’s decree would jeopardize her office’s ability to secure convictions.

Johnson told reporters his order will nonetheless remain as-is, arguing the text “does not necessarily” involve his office in any potential charges against federal immigration agents despite saying “CPD Supervisors must ... at the direction of the Mayor’s Office, make a referral of felony matters to the Cook County State’s Attorney.”

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CONGRESSIONAL HEARING: Acting head of ICE defends officers’ actions before Congress on Tuesday. **Nation & World**

URGING ACTION: Gov. Pritzker says Democratic governors should confront Trump, seek accountability for immigration actions. **Page 5**

Art Institute acquires Rockwell’s painting of the Cubs

‘The Dugout’ gifted to museum by former Gov. Rauner and wife

By Christopher Borrelli
Chicago Tribune

Norman Rockwell’s “The Dugout,” a classic portrait of slumped Cubs, dejected Cubs, defeated Cubs, a morose team resigned to an existential slog of failure, now hangs in the Art Institute of Chicago. It was gifted to the museum by former Illinois Gov. Bruce Rauner and his wife, Diana, who have had it hanging in their home for the past 19 years. It was installed on Tuesday morning across from Grant Wood’s “American Gothic.”

It’s not just the first Norman Rockwell painting in the entire collection of the Art Institute — and he painted 323 covers for the

Saturday Evening Post between 1916 and 1963 — it’s probably the first major work in the museum’s collection that depicts a popular sport.

“When the Rauners reached out to see if we were interested, we were absolutely immediately interested,” said Sarah Kelly Oehler, the Art Institute’s chair and chief curator for arts of the Americas. “I had been thinking for years that it would be wonderful to get a Rockwell in our collection, and this, being Chicago, is the perfect painting.”

“The Dugout” is among the most indelible 20th century images of America’s pastime, painted back when it really still was America’s pastime, before faster-moving football and basketball leagues chipped away. It shows a dugout full of hangdog

Turn to Painting, Page 4



Specialists Tim Roby, left, and Chris Shepherd install Norman Rockwell’s “The Dugout,” an iconic 1948 painting about the Cubs, on Tuesday at the Art Institute of Chicago. Former Gov. Bruce Rauner and wife, Diana, gifted the painting to the museum after hanging it in their home for the past 19 years. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

TODAY’S WEATHER



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Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 14

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